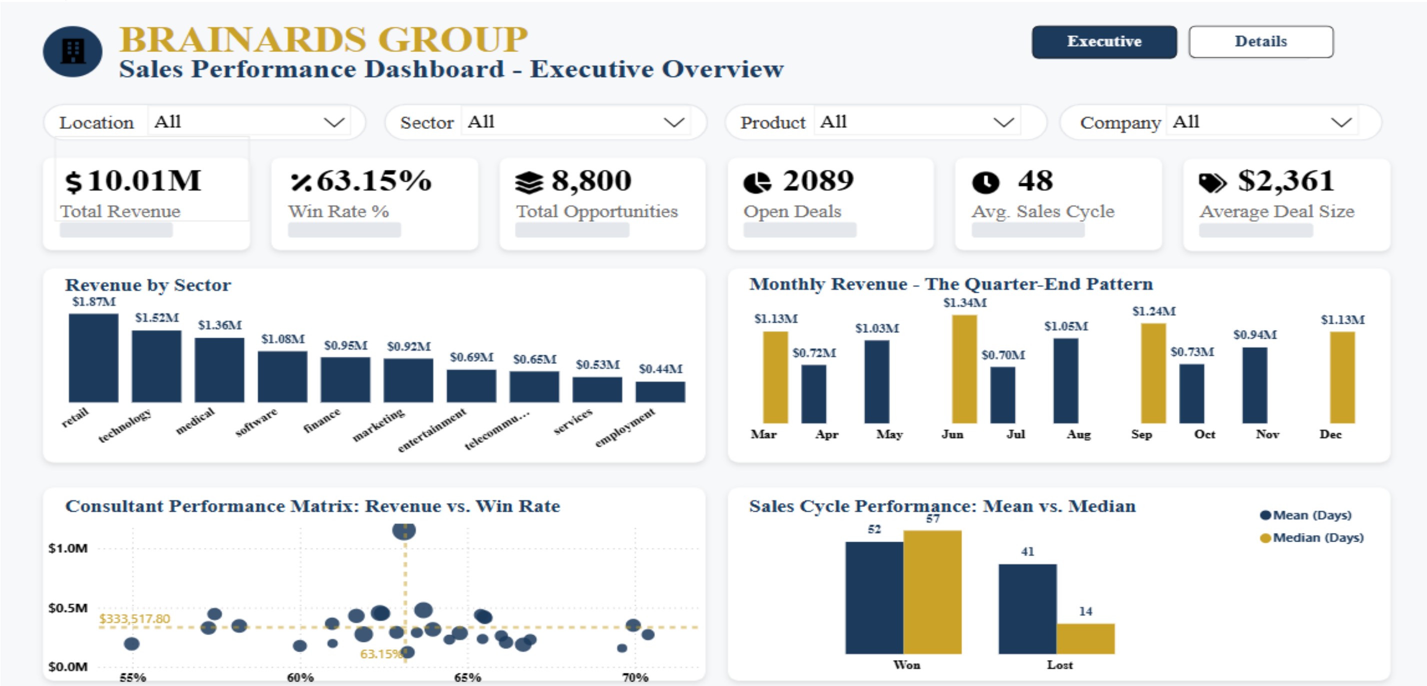
From Raw CRM Data to Business Decisions: Building a Sales Performance Dashboard for Brainards Group with Excel and Power BI

How I transformed 8,800 sales opportunities into actionable business insights through Excel, Power Query, DAX, and Power BI.



Introduction
Every organization generates data. The real challenge isn't collecting it; it's making sense of it.
For many businesses, sales data accumulates every day through customer interactions, product purchases, follow-ups, negotiations, and completed deals. Over time, thousands of records are stored inside CRM systems, but surprisingly few organizations take the time to ask a simple question:
What story is our sales data actually telling us?
That question became the foundation of this project. In this case study, I explored a CRM sales dataset representing the operations of **Brainards Group**, a business consulting and services company. The objective wasn't simply to build a dashboard; it was to understand how the business was performing, identify hidden patterns within the sales pipeline, and generate practical recommendations that management could act on.
Using **Microsoft Excel**, **Power Query**, **DAX**, and **Power BI**, I transformed over **8,800 sales opportunities** into an interactive dashboard that answered critical business questions around sales performance, product profitability, regional productivity, consultant effectiveness, and customer behavior.
More importantly, the project revealed insights that were not immediately obvious from the raw numbers. While the company appeared healthy on the surface, deeper analysis uncovered operational patterns that could significantly influence future growth.
This article walks through the entire process, from understanding the business problem to uncovering the insights that matter most.

Project at a Glance
Industry: Business Consulting & Services
Dataset: CRM Sales Opportunities (Kaggle)
Records Analyzed: 8,800 Sales Opportunities
Tools: Excel, Power Query, DAX, Power BI
Dashboard Pages 2
Key Outcome: Built an interactive sales performance dashboard that answered six business questions and generated actionable recommendations.

About Brainards Group

Brainards Group is a business consulting and professional services organization that works with clients across multiple industries. Like many growing consulting firms, success depends on consistently converting opportunities into revenue while managing relationships across different products, regions, consultants, and client sectors.

Although the organization in this project is presented as **Brainards Group**, the analysis was conducted using a publicly available CRM sales dataset from Kaggle (link). The dataset models a consulting firm's complete sales pipeline, from initial engagement through successful or unsuccessful deal closure.

The Business Problem

Imagine gathering the leadership team in a meeting and asking a few seemingly simple questions. Which industry sector generates the most revenue? Which consultants consistently outperform everyone else? Which products contribute the most to overall sales? Why do some opportunities close while others fail?

Now imagine everyone giving a different answer.

Not because they are wrong. But because everyone is relying on experience, assumptions, or isolated reports instead of evidence.

That was the central problem this project aimed to solve.

The organization possessed valuable sales data, but lacked a unified view of performance. Important business decisions were being made based on fragmented information rather than measurable insights. Without proper analysis, management could not confidently answer these questions.

This project was hence designed to replace assumptions with evidence.

Project Objectives

The primary objective was to analyze the organization's sales pipeline and build an interactive dashboard capable of supporting data-driven decision-making. Specifically, the project sought to:

- Understand overall sales performance across the organization.
- Evaluate revenue generation across different industry sectors.
- Measure regional sales performance.
- Identify the products contributing most to revenue.
- Examine sales cycle duration and deal outcomes.
- Discover hidden patterns within the CRM data.
- Translate analytical findings into actionable business recommendations.

Rather than producing descriptive statistics alone, the goal was to answer meaningful business questions that leadership could use to improve operations.

Business Questions

Before opening Power BI or designing any visuals, I wanted to be clear about what success would look like. Rather than exploring the data aimlessly, I defined a set of business questions that would guide the entire analysis.

These questions became the foundation of the project. Every transformation, DAX measure, KPI, and visualization was built with one purpose in mind: to provide evidence-based answers that could help management better understand the business and make more informed decisions. The six business questions were:

Q1: Which sectors generate the most revenue, and are we spending our energy in the right places?

Understanding where revenue comes from helps determine whether the company's sales efforts are focused on the markets that contribute most to growth.

Q2: What actually separates a won deal from a lost one - agent, sector, product, or something else?

Winning more business isn't just about closing deals; it's about understanding the factors that consistently lead to success and identifying the reasons opportunities are lost.

Q3: How long does it really take to close business, and what does that tell us about how we sell?

Examining the sales cycle provides insight into the efficiency of the sales process and highlights opportunities to improve pipeline management.

Q4: Who are our strongest performers, and how does each consultant compare to the team?
Sales performance often varies across individuals. Identifying top performers helps uncover best practices that can be shared across the organization while also revealing where additional support may be needed.
Q5: Which products generate the most revenue, and how do they contribute to overall sales performance?
Evaluating product performance helps identify high-value offerings, understand their contribution to revenue, and support better product positioning and sales strategies.
Q6: Which regions contribute the most revenue, and how does performance vary across regions?
Comparing regional performance helps determine whether differences are driven by market conditions, sales activity, or operational effectiveness, allowing management to make more targeted decisions.
These questions shaped every stage of the project, from data preparation and dashboard design to the insights uncovered and the recommendations presented at the end of the analysis.

About the Dataset
The analysis was conducted using the **CRM Sales Opportunities** dataset published on Kaggle.📁 [Dataset Link]
The dataset simulates the complete sales process of a consulting organization, capturing every opportunity from customer engagement through final outcome. It consists of **four related tables** containing operational data across customers, products, consultants, and sales opportunities, accompanied by a data dictionary documenting every field.

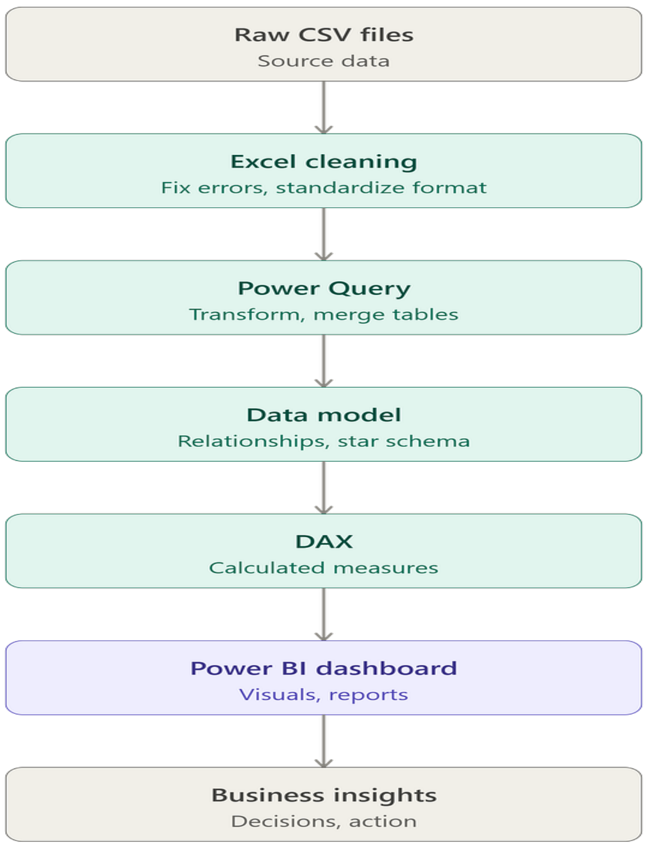
Dataset Structure
Accounts: Company information including sector, year established, annual revenue, employee count, headquarters(office location).
Sales Pipeline: Every sales opportunity from engagement through deal closure.
Sales Teams: Sales consultants, managers, and regional offices.
Products: Product catalogue with pricing information.
After importing the data, the final analytical model contained:
8,800 sales opportunities
85 client accounts
35 sales consultants
3 regional offices
7 products
The Sales Pipeline table served as the central fact table, while the remaining tables provided supporting dimensions for building relationships and performing analysis.

Tools Used
This project combined several Microsoft analytics tools, with each tool serving a distinct purpose within the workflow.
Microsoft Excel: Data import, inspection, cleaning, validation, and consolidation of the CSV files into a single workbook.
Power Query: Data transformation, relationship preparation, and preprocessing before analysis.
DAX: Creation of calculated measures, KPIs, and business metrics used throughout the dashboard.
Power BI Desktop: Data modeling, visualization, dashboard development, and interactive reporting.
Instead of relying on a single application, the project followed a complete analytics workflow beginning with raw data preparation and ending with an executive-ready business dashboard.

Project Workflow
The overall process followed a structured analytics lifecycle.
1. Understand the business context.
2. Explore the CRM dataset.
3. Clean and validate the data in Microsoft Excel.

4. Consolidate the datasets into a single workbook.
5. Import the cleaned data into Power BI.
6. Perform additional transformations using Power Query.
7. Build relationships between the tables.
8. Create DAX measures and KPIs.
9. Design an executive dashboard.
10. Analyze patterns within the data.
11. Translate insights into practical business recommendations.

This approach ensured that every visualization was directly linked to a business question rather than being created simply for presentation.



Data Preparation, Data Modeling, and Dashboard Development

At this point, I had a clear understanding of the business problem, the available data, and the questions I wanted the analysis to answer. The next step was preparing the data for analysis.

Like most real-world analytics projects, the dataset wasn't immediately ready for reporting. Before creating a single visualization, I spent time understanding the relationships between the tables, checking data quality, and building a reliable analytical model.

Data Preparation

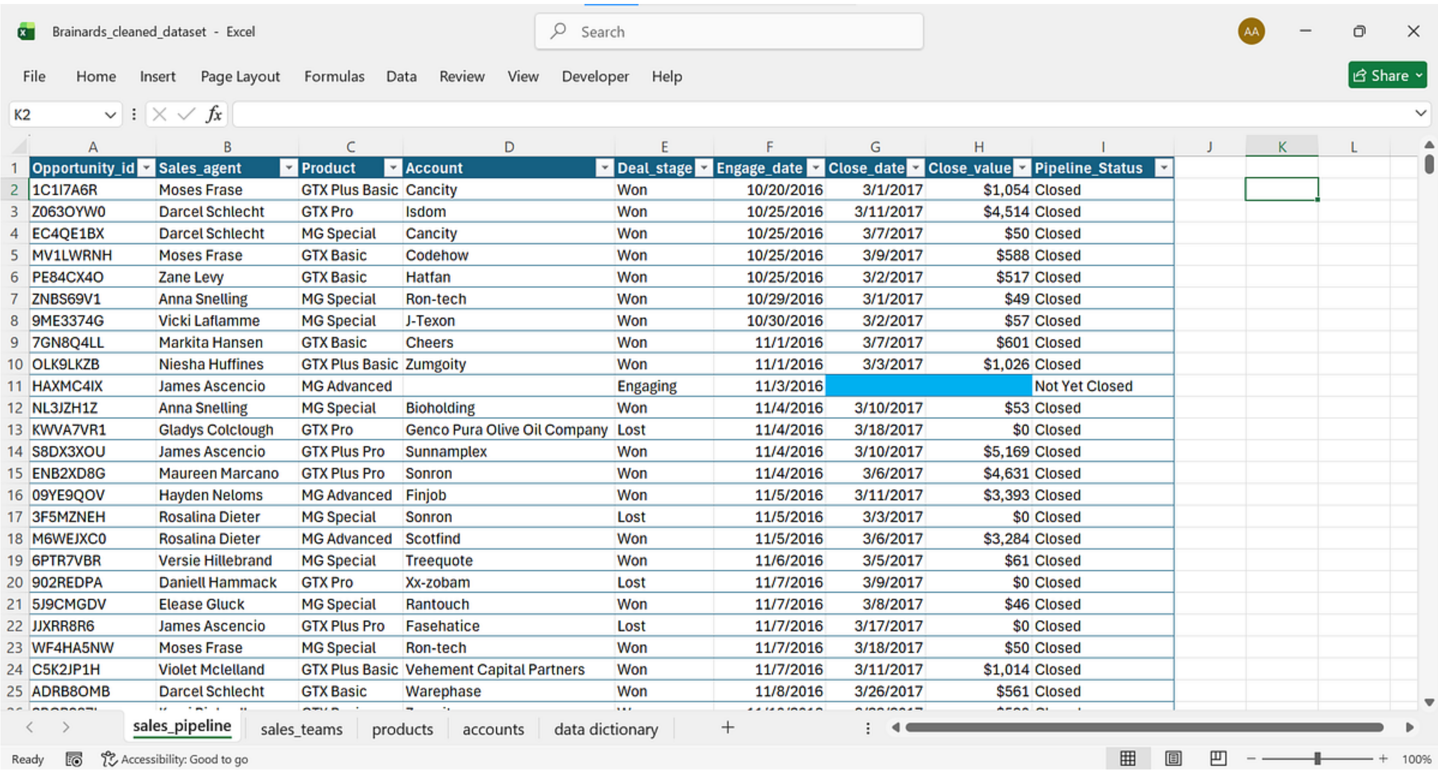
The dataset was downloaded as **four separate CSV files**, with each file representing a different part of the business.

Rather than importing everything directly into Power BI, I first worked in **Microsoft Excel**. Excel provided a convenient environment for inspecting the raw data, identifying inconsistencies, and ensuring each table was suitable for analysis before moving into Power BI.

Each CSV file was imported into a single Excel workbook while remaining on separate worksheets. This made it easier to review the data as one project rather than five disconnected files.

Data Cleaning Process
Before analysis began, I carried out several data quality checks to ensure the dashboard would reflect the business accurately.
The cleaning process included:
Checking for Duplicate Records: Duplicate opportunity records can inflate revenue, distort win rates, and misrepresent consultant performance. I ran a full duplicate check across all four tables, on the full row and separately on the opportunity_id key and found **zero duplicates**. Rather than skip this step because nothing turned up, I documented it as a positive validation result: the data was confirmed clean on this dimension, not just assumed to be.
Standardizing Values: A closer inspection of the categorical fields did turn up two genuine issues. In the accounts table, the sector field contained a misspelling, **"technolgy"** instead of **"technology"** and the location field had **"Philipines"** instead of **"Philippines."** Both would have silently fragmented any sector- or country-level rollup until corrected.
A more consequential issue turned up in the sales_pipeline table: one product was logged as **"GTXPro"** (no space) instead of **"GTX Pro",** the exact name used in the Products table. Left uncorrected, this single mismatch would have broken the relationship between the two tables for that product, causing its revenue to silently disappear from any product-level report with no error message. I also validated for stray whitespace and inconsistent casing across every text column and found none, another clean result worth documenting rather than assuming.
Validating Date Fields: The Engage Date and Close Date columns were reviewed to ensure they were recognized as proper date fields. This was particularly important because later calculations depended on accurate date values, including:
Sales cycle duration
Monthly trends
Quarterly analysis
Time-based KPIs
Handling Missing Values: One observation that stood out during data exploration was the presence of missing values within the Sales Pipeline table. Initially, this appeared to be a data quality issue.
After closer inspection, however, it became clear that these missing values represented **active sales opportunities** that had not yet reached a final outcome. For example:
Close Date was blank because the deal was still open.
Close Value was empty because revenue had not yet been realized.
A small number of Account fields were also blank for opportunities still in progress.
Instead of deleting these records, I intentionally retained them. Removing them would have excluded active opportunities from the analysis and produced an incomplete view of the organization’s sales pipeline.
This is a good example of why understanding the business context is just as important as cleaning the data. Not every blank value represents poor data quality.

Data Validation
Finally, I verified that:
every opportunity had a valid sales agent,
products matched the Products table,
accounts matched the Accounts table,
and relationships between the datasets could be established successfully.
Only after these checks was the data imported into Power BI.



Opportunity_id	Sales_agent	Product	Account	Deal_stage	Engage_date	Close_date	Close_value	Pipeline_Status
1C1I7A6R	Moses Frase	GTX Plus Basic	Cancity	Won	10/20/2016	3/1/2017	$1,054	Closed
Z063OYW0	Darcel Schlecht	GTX Pro	Isdom	Won	10/25/2016	3/11/2017	$4,514	Closed
EC4QE1BX	Darcel Schlecht	MG Special	Cancity	Won	10/25/2016	3/7/2017	$50	Closed
MV1LWRNH	Moses Frase	GTX Basic	Codehow	Won	10/25/2016	3/9/2017	$588	Closed
PE84CX4O	Zane Levy	GTX Basic	Hatfan	Won	10/25/2016	3/2/2017	$517	Closed
ZNBS69V1	Anna Snelling	MG Special	Ron-tech	Won	10/29/2016	3/1/2017	$49	Closed
9ME3374G	Vicki Laflamme	MG Special	J-Texon	Won	10/30/2016	3/2/2017	$57	Closed
7GN8Q4LL	Markita Hansen	GTX Basic	Cheers	Won	11/1/2016	3/7/2017	$601	Closed
OLK9LKZB	Niesha Huffines	GTX Plus Basic	Zumgoity	Won	11/1/2016	3/3/2017	$1,026	Closed
HAXMC4IX	James Ascencio	MG Advanced		Engaging	11/3/2016			Not Yet Closed
NL3JZH1Z	Anna Snelling	MG Special	Bioholding	Won	11/4/2016	3/10/2017	$53	Closed
KWVA7VR1	Gladys Colclough	GTX Pro	Genco Pura Olive Oil Company	Lost	11/4/2016	3/18/2017	$0	Closed
S8DX3XOU	James Ascencio	GTX Plus Pro	Sunnamplex	Won	11/4/2016	3/10/2017	$5,169	Closed
ENB2XD8G	Maureen Marcano	GTX Plus Pro	Sonron	Won	11/4/2016	3/6/2017	$4,631	Closed
09YE9QOV	Hayden Neloms	MG Advanced	Finjob	Won	11/5/2016	3/11/2017	$3,393	Closed
3F5MZNEH	Rosalina Dieter	MG Special	Sonron	Lost	11/5/2016	3/3/2017	$0	Closed
M6WEJXC0	Rosalina Dieter	MG Advanced	Scotfind	Won	11/5/2016	3/6/2017	$3,284	Closed
6PTR7VBR	Versie Hillebrand	MG Special	Treequote	Won	11/6/2016	3/5/2017	$61	Closed
902REDPA	Daniell Hammack	GTX Pro	Xx-zobam	Lost	11/7/2016	3/9/2017	$0	Closed
5J9CMGDV	Elease Gluck	MG Special	Rantouch	Won	11/7/2016	3/8/2017	$46	Closed
JJXRR8R6	James Ascencio	GTX Plus Pro	Fasehatice	Lost	11/7/2016	3/17/2017	$0	Closed
WF4HA5NW	Moses Frase	MG Special	Ron-tech	Won	11/7/2016	3/18/2017	$50	Closed
C5K2JP1H	Violet Mclelland	GTX Plus Basic	Vehement Capital Partners	Won	11/7/2016	3/11/2017	$1,014	Closed
ADRB8OMB	Darcel Schlecht	GTX Basic	Warephase	Won	11/8/2016	3/26/2017	$561	Closed

Building the Data Model

Once the cleaned workbook was imported into Power BI, I used **Power Query** to perform the remaining transformations and prepare the data model.

Instead of combining everything into one massive table, I preserved the dataset's relational structure. This approach follows **star-schema** principles, making the model easier to maintain and significantly improving report performance.

The **Sales Pipeline** table became the central fact table because it records every sales opportunity. The remaining tables served as dimensions that describe different aspects of each opportunity. This approach improves both performance and maintainability in Power BI.

Creating a Dedicated Date Table

One of the first enhancements I made after building the relationships was creating a dedicated **Date Table**.

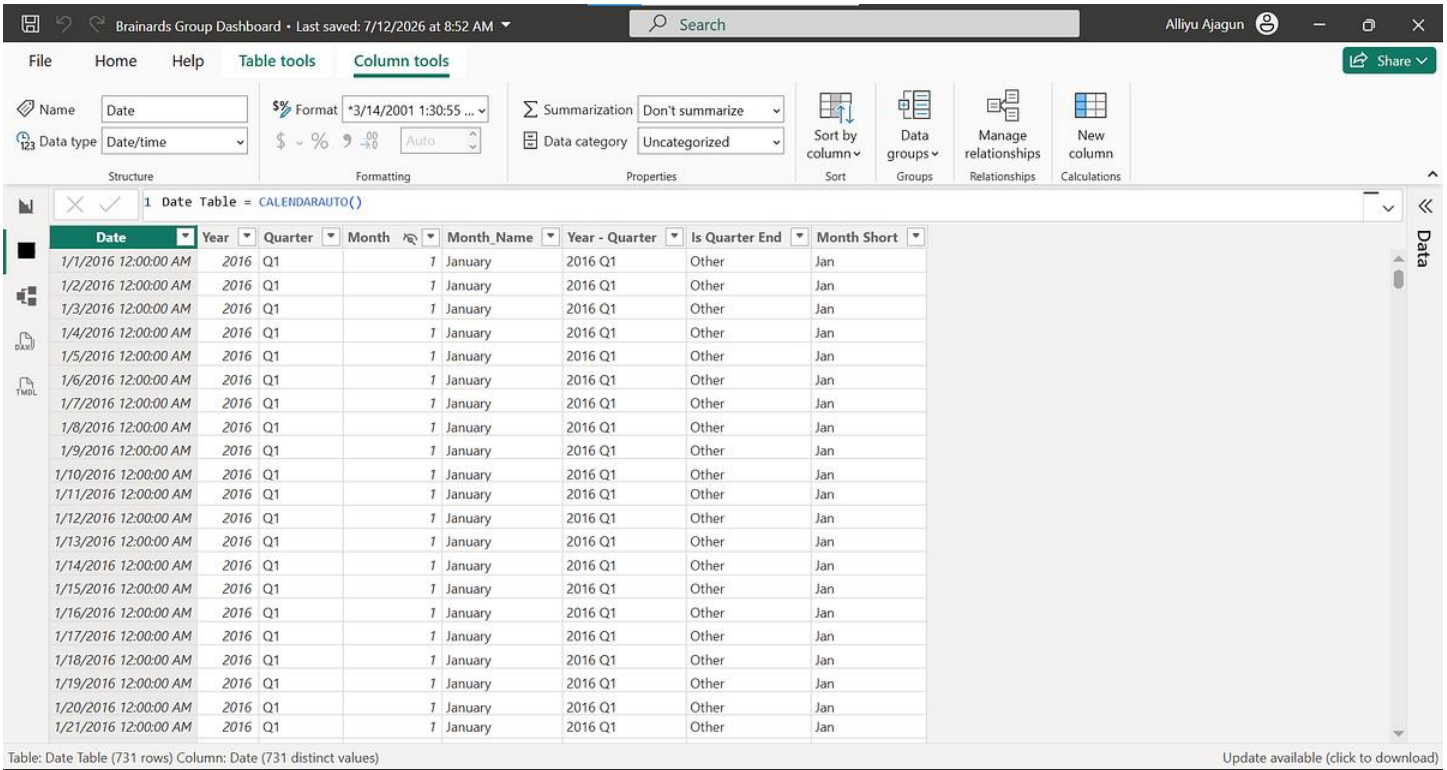
Although the Sales Pipeline table already contained *Engage Date* and *Close Date* columns, relying directly on these fields for time-based analysis can lead to inconsistent filtering and limits the flexibility of reporting.

To solve this, I created a separate calendar table using Power BI's built-in CALENDARAUTO() function. I chose **CALENDARAUTO()** because it automatically scans all date columns in the model and generates a continuous calendar covering the entire date range in the dataset. This eliminates the need to manually specify start and end dates and ensures the calendar remains valid if additional data is added in the future.

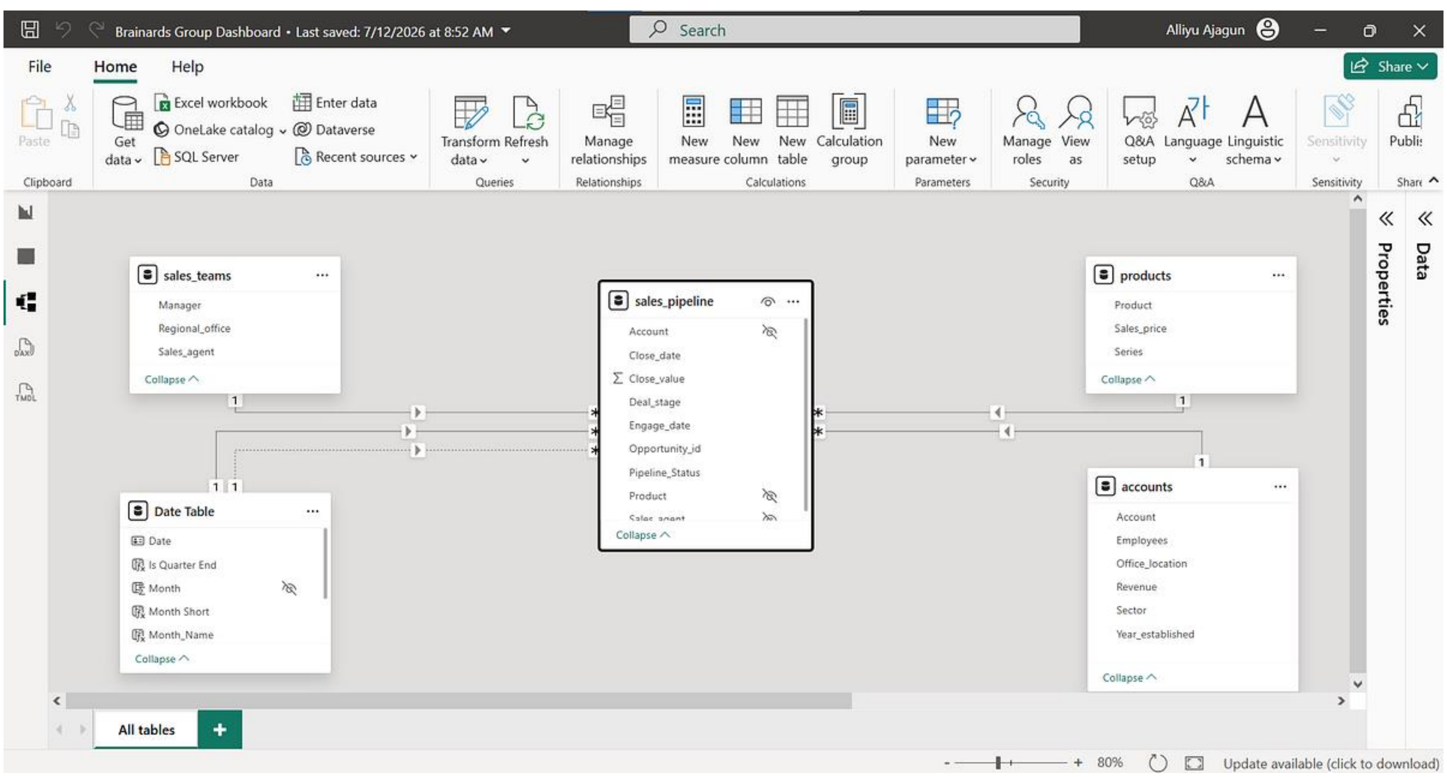
After generating the calendar, I enriched it with several calculated columns to support time intelligence and improve report usability, including:

Year, Quarter, Month Number, Month Name

These additional fields made it possible to analyze sales performance across different time periods without repeatedly writing complex DAX expressions.



Once the Date Table was created, it was also linked to the **Sales Pipeline** table through the appropriate date field, enabling consistent date filtering across the entire report.
The relationships looked like this:



Building proper relationships ensured that filtering one table automatically updated every connected visualization. Selecting a consultant, for example, immediately filtered products, accounts, revenue, and sales outcomes without requiring duplicate calculations.

Creating Business Measures with DAX

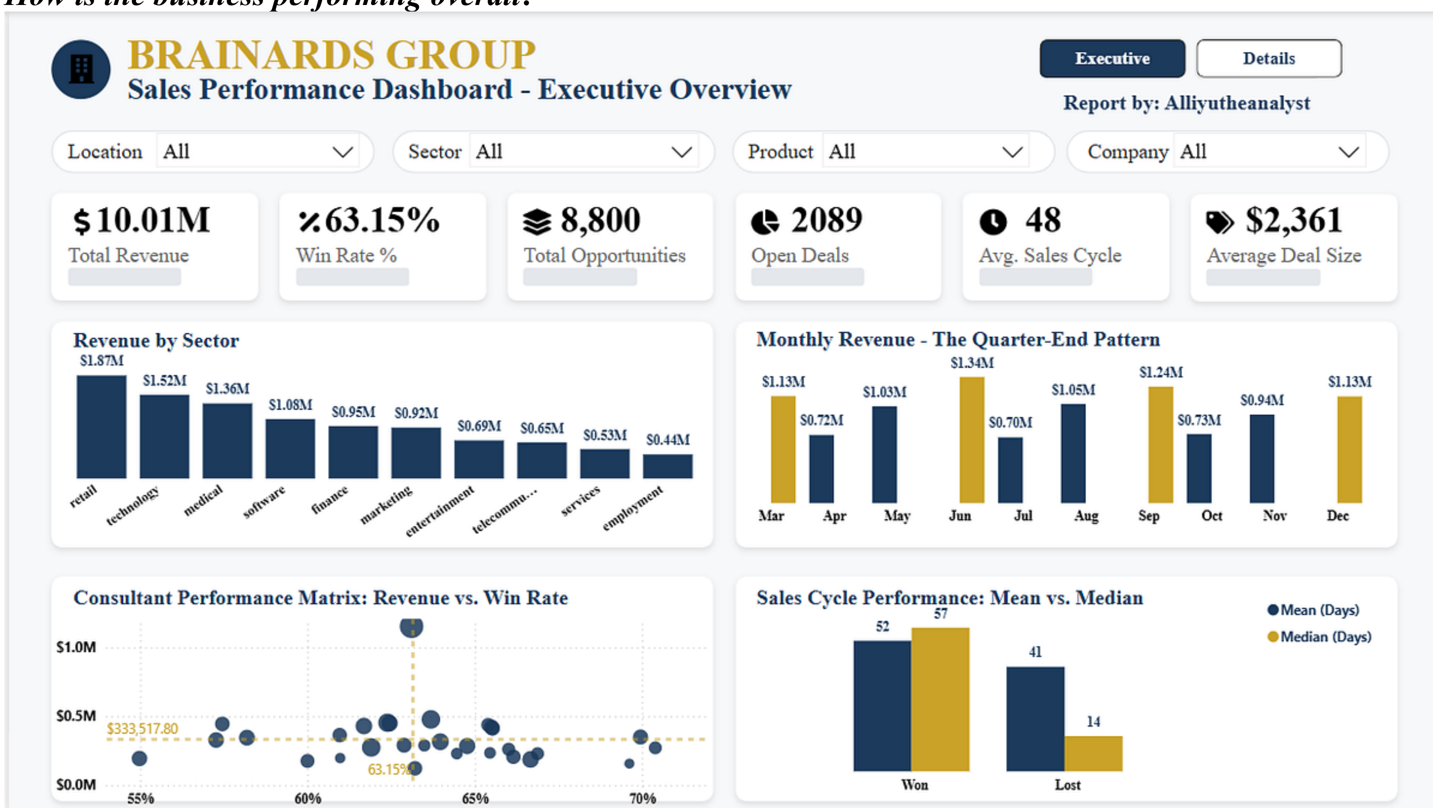
With the model in place, the next step was creating the measures that would drive the dashboard.
Rather than relying solely on raw fields, I developed DAX measures to calculate the key performance indicators required by management.
Some of the measures included:
Total Revenue, Total Opportunities, Won Deals, Lost Deals, Open Opportunities, Win Rate, Average Deal Size, Average Sales Cycle, etc
These measures formed the backbone of every visualization in the dashboard. Using DAX also ensured that values updated dynamically whenever users interacted with slicers and filters.

Designing the Dashboard

A dashboard should do more than display charts; it should answer questions. With that principle in mind, I designed the report around the needs of decision-makers rather than around the dataset itself.
To make the dashboard interactive, I added slicers that allow users to filter the report by region, manager, sales consultant, product, and time period. This enables decision-makers to move seamlessly from organization-wide trends to individual performance without rebuilding reports.
The final solution consisted of **two interactive dashboard pages**, each serving a different purpose.

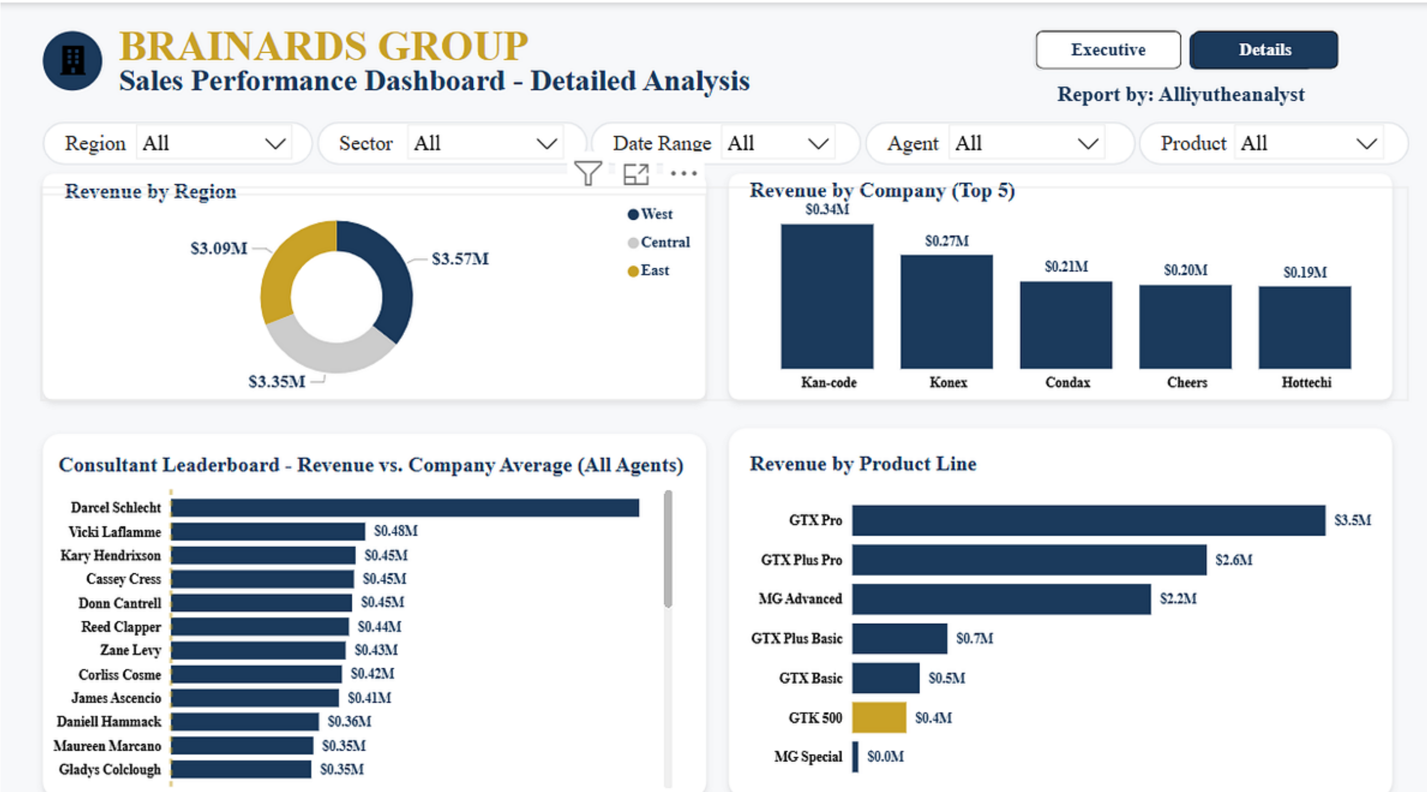
Executive Dashboard

The first page provides a high-level overview of the organization's sales performance. This page was designed for executives who need to understand business performance within a few minutes.
Rather than overwhelming users with detail, this page focuses on answering one question:
How is the business performing overall?



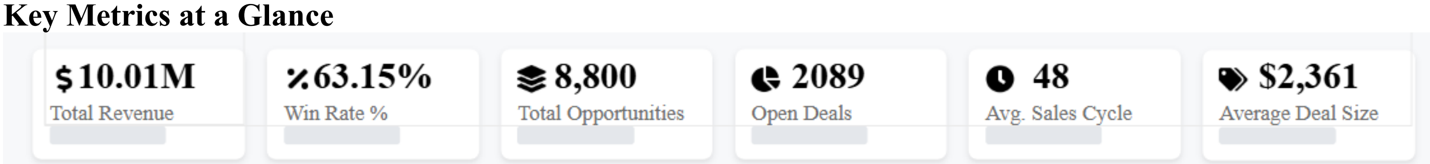
Executive Dashboard
The executive dashboard includes KPI cards for:
Total Revenue, Total Opportunities, Open Deals, Win Rate, Average Deal Size, and Average Sales Cycle

Detailed Performance Dashboard
The second page dives deeper into operational performance. This page was designed for sales managers who need to understand *why* the numbers look the way they do.
This page allows management to move beyond summary statistics and identify specific opportunities for improvement.



Detailed Dashboard
Every visualization in the dashboard was designed to answer one or more of these questions.

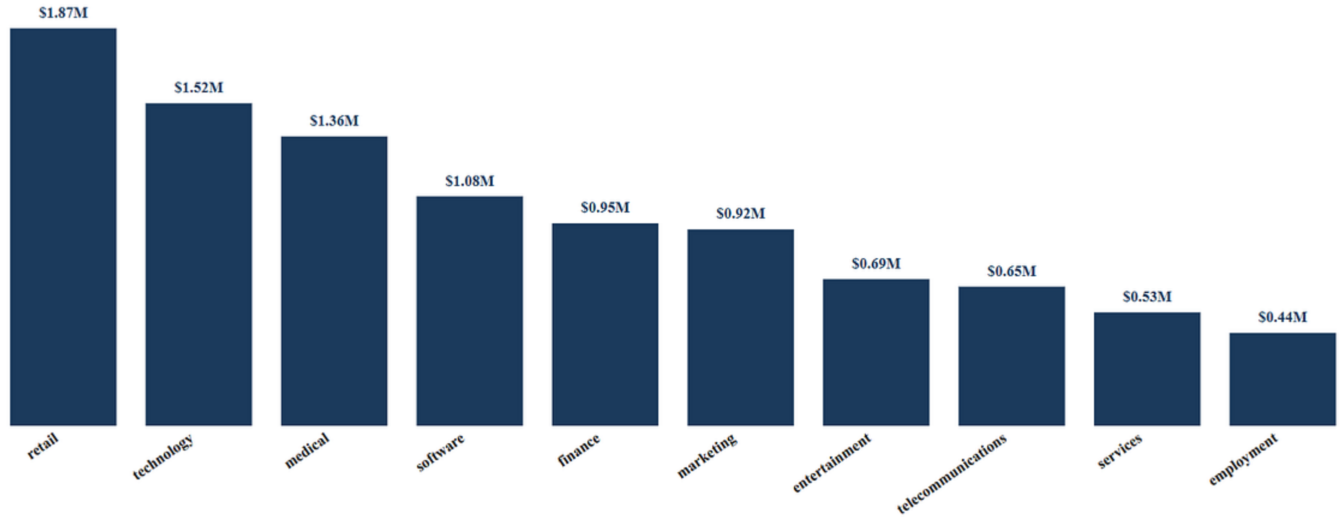
Key Metrics at a Glance



Total Revenue $10.01M
Average Win Rate 63.15%
Total Opportunities 8,800
Open Deal 2089
Average Sales Cycle 48 (blended across all closed deals i.e won and lost combined)
Average Deal Size $2361

From Questions to Insights: What the Data Revealed
With the dashboard complete, it was time to answer the six questions that guided the entire project.
Some of the findings confirmed what I expected. Others completely challenged my assumptions. However, those unexpected discoveries turned out to be the most valuable.

Business Question 1
Which sectors generate the most revenue, and are we spending our energy in the right places?



Revenue by Sector
At first glance, the answer appeared straightforward.
The **Retail**, **Technology**, and **Medical** sectors generated the largest share of the company's revenue, making them the strongest-performing industries in the portfolio. Naturally, the first assumption would be that these sectors outperform because the sales team closes deals more effectively there.
The data told a different story.
When I compared **win rates across every sector**, I discovered that they were remarkably consistent, fluctuating only between **61% and 65%**.

Sector	Win Rate %
employment	62.59%
entertainment	64.68%
finance	61.17%
marketing	64.85%
medical	62.32%
retail	63.06%
services	63.35%
software	63.92%
technology	63.42%
telecommunications	62.50%

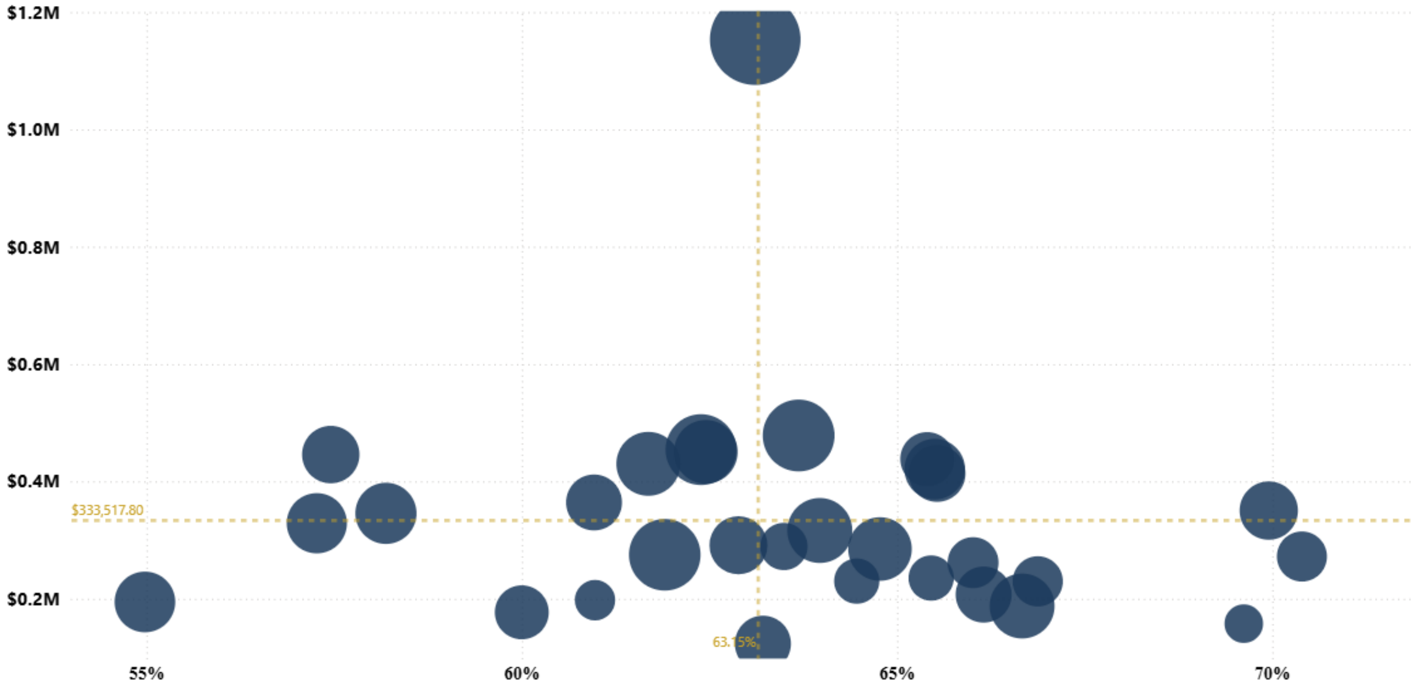
That means the company is not significantly better at selling into one industry than another. Instead, these sectors generate more revenue simply because the company has more opportunities within them.
In other words, **volume, not superior conversion, is driving revenue.**

Why this matters

This changes the conversation for management. Rather than asking, *"How do we improve our win rate in Retail?"* the better question becomes, *"How do we generate more qualified opportunities in sectors where we already convert well?"*
Growth is more likely to come from expanding the pipeline than from trying to squeeze marginal improvements out of already healthy conversion rates.

Business Question 2

What actually separates a won deal from a lost one? agent, sector, product, or something else?



Consultants Performance Matrix: Revenue by Win Rate

Initially, I expected factors like industry sector or product mix to explain the differences between successful and unsuccessful deals.

Instead, one variable stood out above everything else. The **sales consultant**. Across consultants with comparable workloads, win rates ranged from **55% to 70%**. That is a substantial performance gap.

Even more striking was the revenue concentration. Just **three consultants generated more than 20% of the company's total revenue**, while the highest-performing consultant produced **9.3 times** the revenue of the lowest-performing active consultant.

This wasn't a client concentration problem. It was a people concentration problem. The organization's growth depends heavily on a small group of exceptional performers.

What surprised me: Most consulting firms worry about losing their biggest client. This analysis suggests Brainards Group should be equally concerned about losing one of its highest-performing consultants. If one of those individuals leaves, the impact on revenue could be immediate.

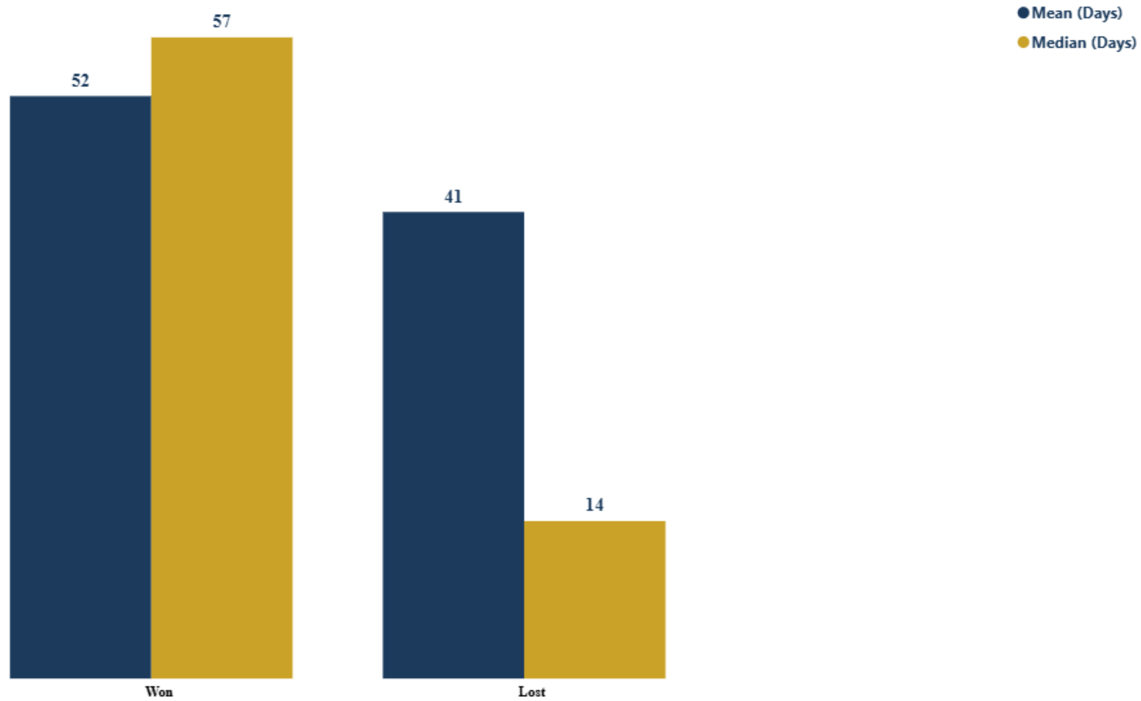
Why this matters

Rather than treating top performers simply as high achievers, management should view them as valuable sources of institutional knowledge.

Understanding how they qualify prospects, structure conversations, handle objections, and manage follow-ups could help elevate performance across the entire sales team.

The biggest difference between winning and losing deals isn't the industry or the product; it's the person leading the sale.

Business Question 3
How long does it really take to close business, and what does that tell us about how we sell?



Sales Cycle Performance: Mean vs Median

One of the most interesting discoveries came from examining sales cycle duration more closely. The 48-day figure on the executive summary blends every closed deal together, but won and lost deals don’t actually behave the same way, and averaging them into one number hides that. Split apart, the **average won deal** closed in approximately **57 days**, suggesting a relatively consistent two-month sales cycle.

Lost deals, however, revealed a much more complicated story. While the **average lost deal** lasted **41 days**, the **median lost deal** survived only **14 days**.

That difference immediately caught my attention.

It indicated that most unsuccessful deals fail quickly, while a much smaller group of lost deals remains in the pipeline for months before eventually being marked as lost. These long-running unsuccessful opportunities distort the average and quietly consume valuable selling time.

What I noticed: There are actually two different kinds of losses. The first group fails quickly. Those are inexpensive.

The second group lingers for weeks or months before ultimately producing no revenue at all. Those are the costly ones.

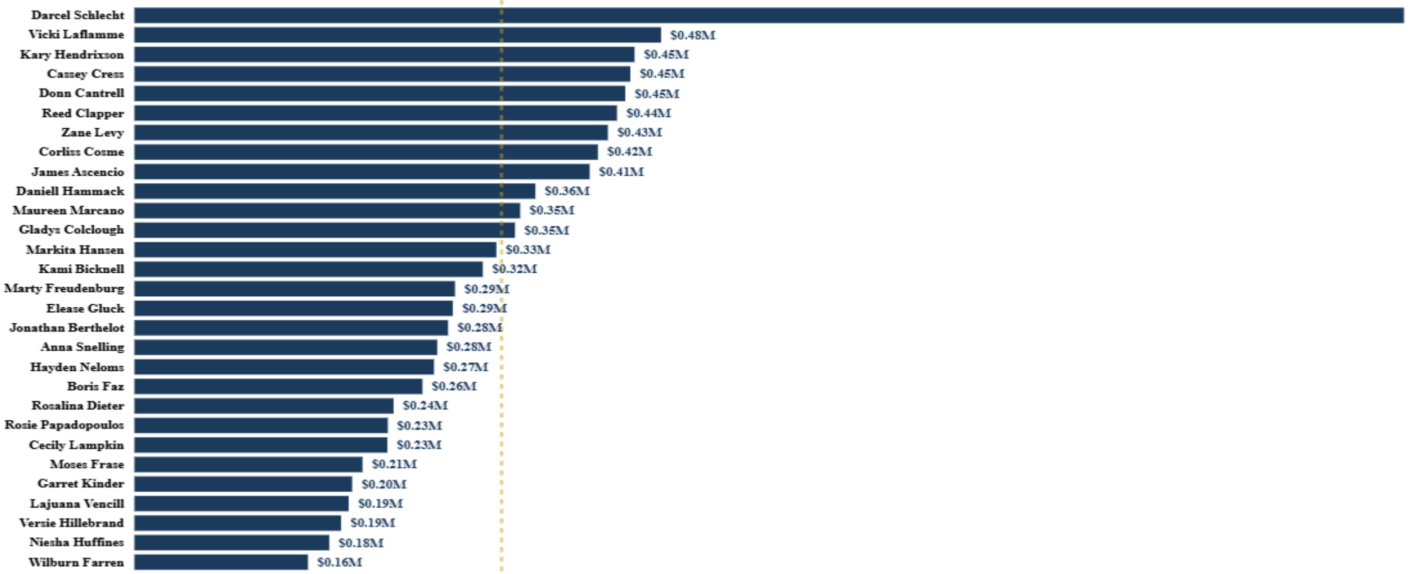
Why this matters

Salespeople only have a limited amount of time. Every month spent chasing an opportunity that will never close is time that could have been invested in a better prospect.

The company doesn’t simply lose deals; it sometimes loses time, and time may be the more expensive resource.

Business Question 4

Who are our strongest performers, and how does each consultant compare to the team?



Consultants Leaderboard

Ranking consultants by revenue immediately highlighted several outstanding performers.

However, the real insight wasn't who ranked first. It was how far ahead they were. The gap between the highest-performing consultant and the lowest-performing active consultant was more than **nine-fold**. Performance wasn't evenly distributed across the organization. A relatively small group of consultants consistently generated a disproportionate share of business.

Sales_agent	Win Rate %
Hayden Neloms	70.39%
Maureen Marcano	69.95%
Wilburn Farren	69.62%
Cecily Lampkin	66.88%
Versie Hillebrand	66.67%
Moses Frase	66.15%
Boris Faz	66.01%
James Ascencio	65.53%
Corliss Cosme	65.50%
Rosalina Dieter	65.45%
Reed Clapper	65.40%
Jonathan Berthelot	64.77%
Rosie Papadopoulos	64.46%
Kami Bicknell	63.97%
Vicki Laflamme	63.69%
Elease Gluck	63.49%
Violet Mclelland	63.21%
Darcel Schlecht	63.11%
Marty Freudenburg	62.89%
Cassey Cress	62.45%
Kary Hendrixson	62.39%
Anna Snelling	61.90%
Zane Levy	61.69%
Garret Kinder	60.98%
Daniell Hammack	60.96%
Niesha Huffines	60.00%
Gladys Colclough	58.19%
Donn Cantrell	57.45%
Markita Hansen	57.27%
Lajuana Vencill	54.98%

Interestingly, when I checked win-rate comparisons, the consultant generating the highest revenue is not the consultant with the highest win rate. For example, **Darcel Schlecht**, who is the highest revenue earner, has a win rate of **63.11%**, which is almost exactly around the company average, though not among the top performers by win rate. This reinforces an important lesson in sales analytics: closing a high percentage of deals does not automatically translate into generating the highest revenue. Opportunity quality, deal size, and pipeline composition all play equally important roles.

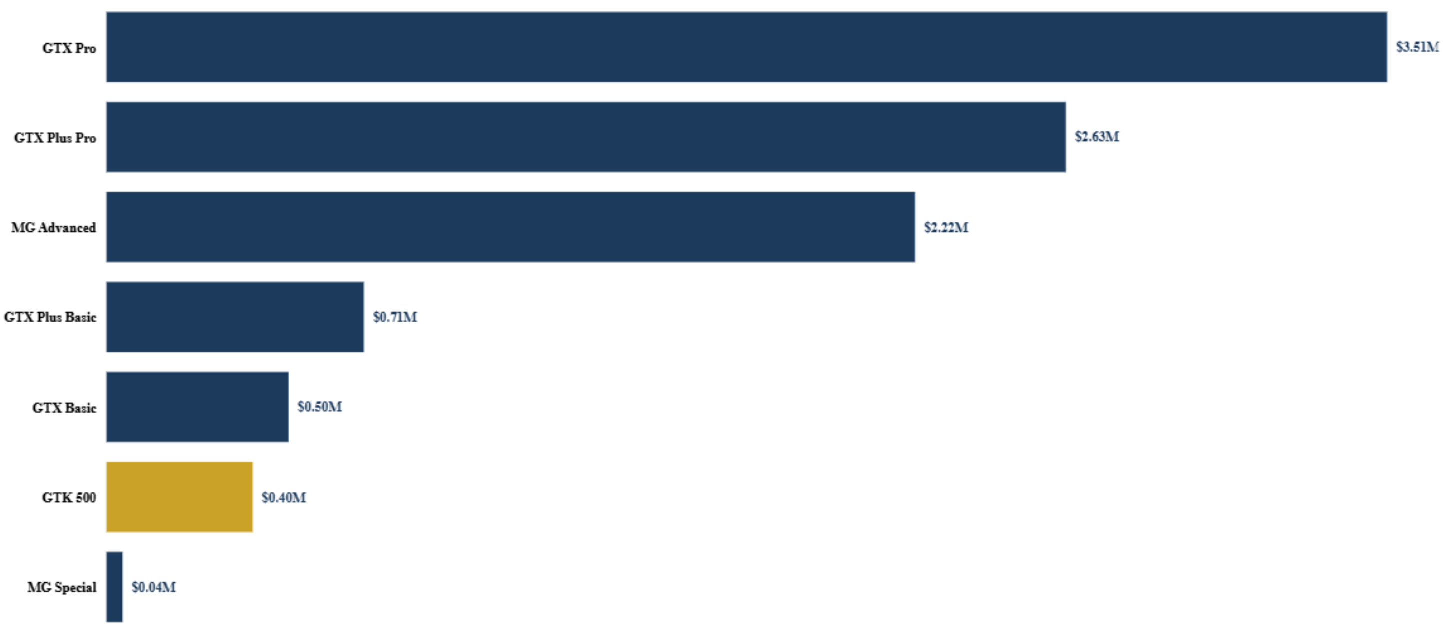
The strongest performers are those who combine healthy conversion rates with strong pipeline management and high-value opportunities.

Why this matters

This finding suggests that consultant performance should never be evaluated using a single metric. Revenue tells us who generates the most value, while win rate reveals who converts opportunities most effectively. Looking at both together provides a more complete picture of performance and helps management identify not only top earners but also consultants whose selling techniques could benefit the wider team.

Business Question 5

Which products generate the most revenue, and how do they contribute to overall sales performance?



Revenue by Product

When I analyzed revenue across the product portfolio, it became clear that not all products contributed equally. A small number of products accounted for a significant share of total revenue, like GTX Pro, GTX Plus Pro, and MG Advanced, while others played a much smaller role.

This uneven distribution is common in many businesses. Some products act as core revenue generators, while others support the portfolio by serving niche customer needs or complementing higher-value offerings.

Among all the products, **GTK 500** stood out for a different reason.

Product	Average Deal Size
GTK 500	$26,707.47
GTX Plus Pro	$5,489.88
GTX Pro	$4,815.61
MG Advanced	$3,388.97
GTX Plus Basic	$1,080.05
GTX Basic	$545.64
MG Special	$55.19

Although the revenue chart highlighted the products contributing most to the business, a deeper look at the data revealed that **GTK 500** recorded the **highest average deal value**, approximately **$26.7K per transaction**, which was more than five times higher than the next highest product.

There was a trade-off, however. **GTK 500** also recorded the **longest average sales cycle**, meaning customers took longer to make purchasing decisions.

Product	Mean (Days)
GTK 500	54
GTX Basic	50
GTX Plus Basic	49
GTX Plus Pro	46
GTX Pro	46
MG Advanced	47
MG Special	48

At first, this might seem like a disadvantage. But in reality, it is exactly what many businesses expect from premium offerings. High-value products often involve longer negotiations, additional approvals, and greater customer evaluation before a purchase is made.

At the opposite end of the portfolio was **MG Special**, with an average deal value of approximately **$55**. The difference was so large that it immediately raised a question.

Was **MG Special** genuinely a low-cost product, or was there a pricing or recording issue within the dataset?

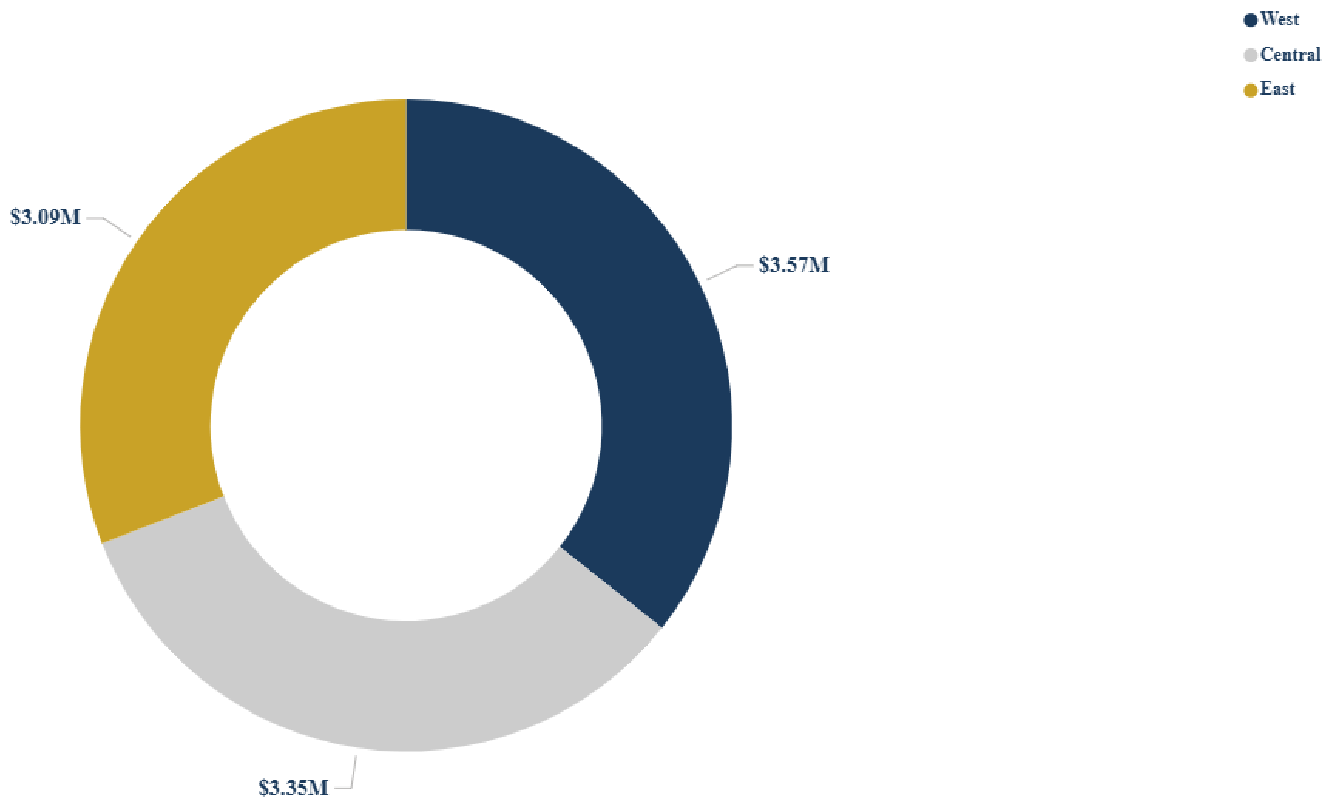
Why this matters

Looking only at total revenue tells us which products currently contribute most to the business. Looking beyond revenue reveals *how* those products generate value.

Revenue is not evenly distributed across the product portfolio. While several products contribute to overall business growth, **GTK 500 distinguishes itself through exceptionally high-value transactions**, making it a strong candidate for premium positioning. Meanwhile, **MG Special's unusually low deal value should be verified before strategic decisions are made.**

Business Question 6

Which regions contribute the most revenue, and how does performance vary across regions?



Revenue by Region

Regional performance revealed one of the most interesting findings in the entire analysis.

At first glance, the **East region** appeared to be underperforming because it generated less revenue than both the Central and West regions. The immediate assumption would be that the East team was simply less effective at closing deals.

However, once I compared regional win rates, the story changed completely.

Regional_office	Win Rate %	Total Opportunities
Central	62.56%	3,512
West	63.94%	2,997
East	63.02%	2,291

The three regions performed remarkably similarly. Those differences are too small to conclude that one region sells significantly better than another. Thus, the real difference came from **opportunity volume**.

Consultants in the East region managed substantially fewer opportunities than their counterparts in Central and West. In other words, they weren't converting fewer deals; they were receiving fewer chances to convert deals in the first place. That distinction completely changes how management should respond.

Why this matters

If management focused only on revenue totals, they might conclude that the East team needed additional sales coaching. The analysis, however, suggests otherwise.

The East region isn't underperforming; it is under-resourced. Improving opportunity volume is likely to have a far greater impact than improving conversion skills.

Beyond the Original Questions

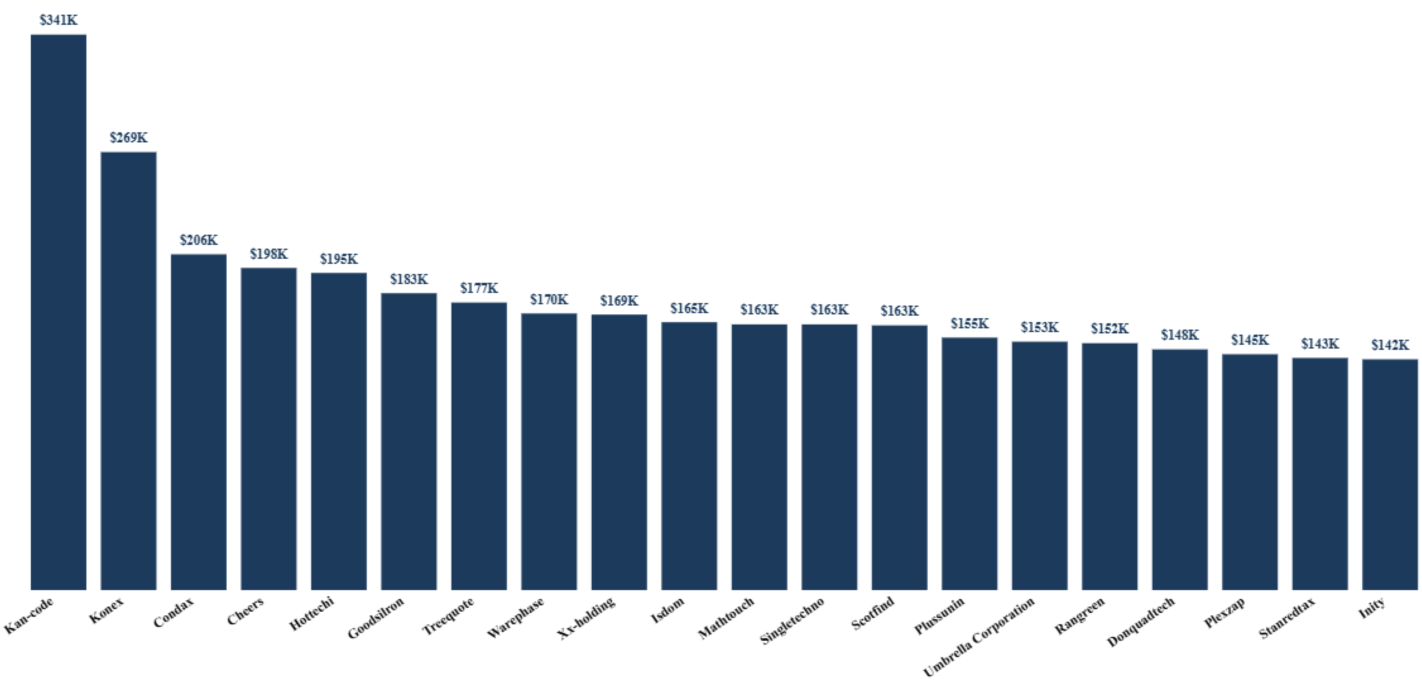
While answering the six business questions addressed the project's primary objectives, exploring the dataset further uncovered several additional patterns that deserve attention.

These weren't questions I initially set out to answer, but they emerged naturally during the analysis and provided an even deeper understanding of how the business operates.

Revenue Is Surprisingly Well Diversified

Many organizations worry about becoming overly dependent on a handful of large clients. I wanted to determine whether that risk existed here. After examining the distribution of revenue across customer accounts, I found the opposite.

Revenue was spread across a broad client base rather than concentrated in just a few organizations. In fact, it took approximately **69% of customer accounts** to generate **80% of total revenue**. This indicates a healthy customer portfolio and reduces the risk associated with losing any single client.

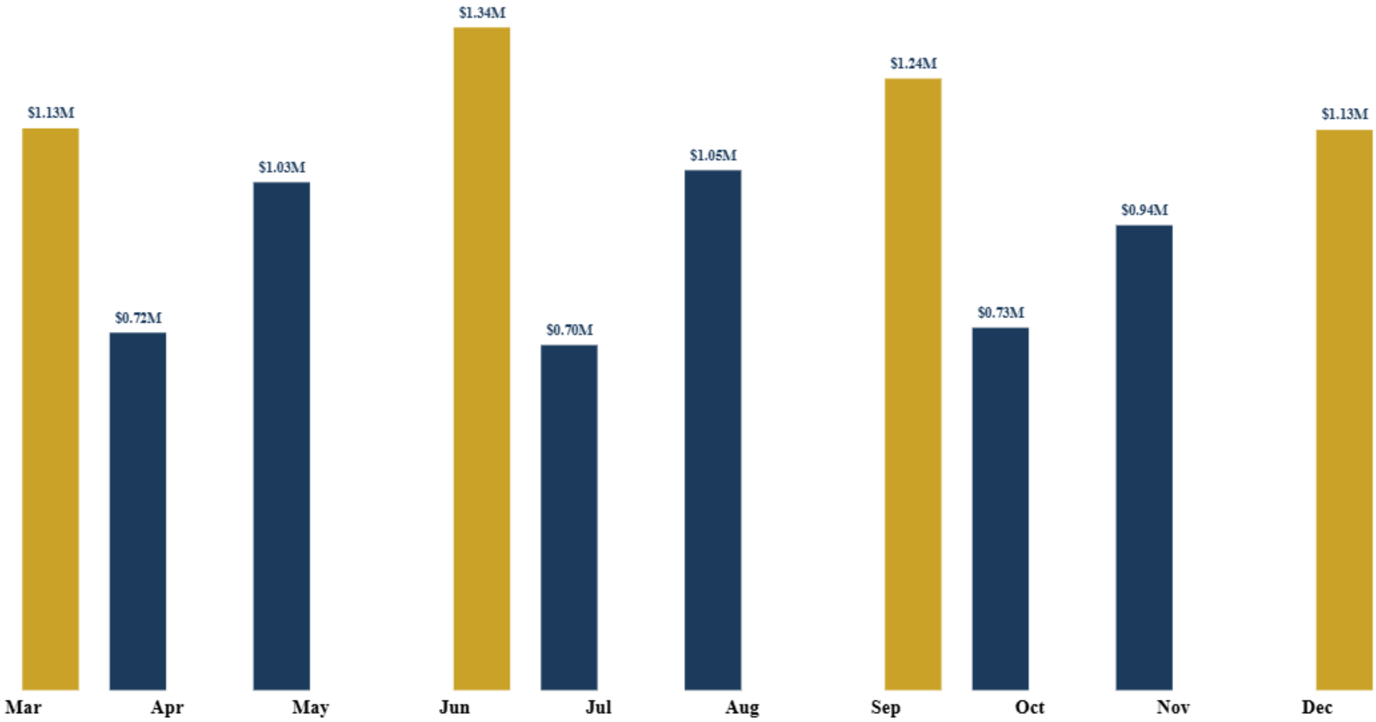


The Business Has a Quarter-End Rhythm

When I analyzed monthly sales performance, another interesting pattern emerged. Revenue consistently peaked in **March, June, September, and December** before declining in the following months.

This is a classic quarter-end sales pattern. Rather than indicating inconsistent business performance, it reflects the tendency for organizations to accelerate negotiations and finalize deals before quarterly reporting periods.

Understanding this rhythm helps management distinguish between normal seasonal fluctuations and genuine performance issues.



Bringing Everything Together

By the end of the analysis, one conclusion became increasingly clear. Brainards Group does not have a sales problem. It has a **visibility problem**.

The company already possesses the data needed to understand its operations. What was missing was a structured way to transform that information into decisions.

The dashboard revealed a business with healthy sector performance, a diversified client base, and strong overall conversion rates. At the same time, it highlighted several operational opportunities that would have remained hidden without deeper analysis.

Most notably:

Revenue is more dependent on a small group of consultants than on any single client.

The East region requires more opportunities, not more coaching.

GTK 500 stands out as a premium product deserving strategic attention.

Long-running unsuccessful opportunities quietly consume valuable selling time.

Growth is more likely to come from increasing opportunity volume than from improving already healthy conversion rates.

Recommendations

Based on the findings from this analysis, I identified several practical recommendations that could help Brainards Group improve its sales performance and make better use of its CRM data.

1. Capture and Replicate the Practices of High-Performing Consultants

Consultant performance varied considerably across the organization. While some consultants consistently generated exceptional revenue, others lagged behind.

Rather than viewing top performers solely as individual successes, management should identify the practices that contribute to their effectiveness. These may include prospect qualification techniques, customer engagement strategies, follow-up processes, and negotiation approaches.

Documenting and sharing these practices through coaching and mentoring programs can help improve overall team performance.

2. Prioritize High-Value Product Strategies
GTK 500 distinguished itself by generating the highest average deal value, despite requiring a longer sales cycle.
This suggests that premium products can produce significant returns when supported by the right sales approach.
Management should continue investing in products that deliver high business value while ensuring that consultants receive adequate support to manage longer and more complex sales cycles.
3. Review Low-Value Product Performance
Products with unusually low average deal values, such as MG Special, should be reviewed to determine whether the observed values reflect genuine pricing strategies or inconsistencies within the underlying data.
A detailed product review will help ensure future strategic decisions are based on accurate information.
4. Monitor Long-Running Sales Opportunities
The analysis showed that many unsuccessful opportunities remain active in the pipeline for extended periods before eventually being marked as lost.
Regular pipeline reviews should be conducted to identify stalled opportunities and either re-engage prospects or formally close inactive deals.
Reducing time spent on unlikely opportunities allows consultants to focus on prospects with a greater likelihood of conversion.
5. Increase Opportunity Generation in the East Region
The East region recorded lower overall revenue than the Central and West regions. However, a closer examination revealed that its sales consultants achieved win rates comparable to the other regions.
This suggests that the issue is not sales capability but a shortage of opportunities entering the pipeline.
Management should consider strengthening marketing campaigns, prospecting efforts, and lead generation activities within the East region to provide consultants with a larger pool of qualified opportunities.
6. Continue Using Data to Support Strategic Decision-Making
Perhaps the most important recommendation is cultural rather than technical.
Dashboards should not simply be reporting tools; they should become part of routine business decision-making.
Regularly reviewing key performance indicators, consultant performance, regional trends, and product performance enables management to respond proactively rather than reactively.

Challenges Encountered
No analytics project is without challenges, and this one was no exception.
Although the dataset was well structured, several aspects required careful interpretation before meaningful analysis could begin.
One of the most important lessons came from understanding that **missing values do not always represent poor-quality data**. Several blank fields within the Sales Pipeline table corresponded to active opportunities that had not yet reached the Won or Lost stage. Removing these records would have produced an incomplete view of the sales pipeline.
Another challenge involved translating business requirements into measurable KPIs. Building the dashboard required careful planning to ensure each visualization answered a specific business question rather than simply presenting data.
Finally, balancing detail with usability was an important design consideration. The objective was to provide sufficient information for exploration while maintaining a clean, intuitive interface suitable for executive decision-makers.

Lessons Learned
This project reinforced several important lessons about business analytics.
The first is that **data rarely tells its story immediately**. Meaningful insights emerge only after asking the right questions and exploring the relationships between variables.
Secondly, dashboards are only as valuable as the business questions they answer. Beginning the project with clearly defined objectives ensured that every transformation, DAX measure, and visualization served a meaningful purpose.

Another important lesson was the value of combining technical skills with business thinking. Building relationships, creating measures, and designing visuals are important, but their real impact comes from translating analytical findings into recommendations that decision-makers can act upon.
Finally, I was reminded that analytics is an iterative process. Some of the most valuable insights, such as the relationship between opportunity volume and regional performance, or the distinction between revenue generation and win rate, were not part of my original expectations. They emerged through continued exploration of the data.

Final Thoughts

This project began with a straightforward objective: analyze a CRM sales dataset and build an interactive Power BI dashboard.
It ended with something much more valuable.
By transforming thousands of raw sales records into meaningful business insights, I was able to identify patterns that would have been difficult to detect through spreadsheets or static reports alone. The analysis demonstrated how data can move beyond reporting past performance to supporting strategic decision-making.
One of the most rewarding aspects of the project was seeing how seemingly simple questions led to deeper discoveries. Regional performance was influenced more by opportunity volume than by sales effectiveness. Revenue depended not only on consultant skill but also on the size and composition of their pipeline. Premium products justified longer sales cycles because of the value they delivered.
These are the kinds of insights that enable organizations to move from intuition to evidence-based decision-making.
More broadly, this project reinforced my belief that successful dashboards are not defined by the number of charts they contain, but by the quality of the conversations they inspire. The goal of analytics is not simply to visualize data; it is to help people ask better questions, make better decisions, and ultimately create better outcomes.

Interactive Dashboard

🔗 **Power BI Dashboard [Link here]**

Project Resources

📁 **GitHub Repository: [Link here]**

📊 **Dataset (Kaggle): [Link here]**

Thank You for Reading

Thank you for taking the time to read through this case study.
If you have feedback, questions, or suggestions, I would love to hear your thoughts. You can also connect with me on LinkedIn to discuss data analytics, Power BI, SQL, or business intelligence projects.
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